

# **Student Movement of 1962–1964:**

## **Introduction:**

The student movement of 1962–1964 in East Pakistan was one of the earliest and strongest democratic challenges to the authoritarian regime of President Ayub Khan. It developed as a response to political repression, constitutional manipulation, educational controversies, and growing regional discrimination. Over these three years, the movement moved through clear stages and involved key figures such as **Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy** and **Governor Abdul Monem Khan**, reaching a crucial flashpoint during the **Dhaka University Convocation on 21 December 1963**.

## **Background**

After imposing martial law in **1958**, Ayub Khan tried to institutionalize his power through the **1962 Constitution, introduced on 8 June 1962**. This constitution created a powerful presidential system, curtailed democratic rights, and weakened representative institutions. Students in East Pakistan saw this as an attempt to silence political participation and to consolidate the dominance of West Pakistan.

## **Beginning of the Movement (1962)**

Protests began soon after the 1962 Constitution went into effect. During **mid and late 1962**, students across Dhaka University, Rajshahi University, and colleges throughout East Pakistan demanded restoration of democracy and civil liberties. The initial stage focused on opposing military rule and rejecting the imposed constitutional framework.

## **Sharif Education Commission Agitation (1962–1963)**

A major spark came from the **Sharif Education Commission Report of 1962**. Students feared that its recommendations would damage secular education and increase central control. From **late 1962 to early 1963**, universities observed strikes, rallies, and nationwide hartals. This struggle broadened the movement beyond politics and drew attention to cultural and educational identity.

## **Role of Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy (1962–1963)**

The movement gained national political weight through the involvement of **Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy**. After being freed from the political restrictions of EBDO in **1962**, he renewed his criticism of Ayub Khan. His public speeches during **1962 and early 1963** encouraged students to intensify their campaign. Suhrawardy's presence connected campus activism with the wider democratic aspirations of East Pakistan.

## **Appointment of Governor Abdul Monem Khan (29 June 1962)**

The appointment of **Abdul Monem Khan** as Governor of East Pakistan on **29 June 1962** marked a new phase. His administration relied heavily on police force, arrests, and intimidation throughout **1963–1964**. His open loyalty to Ayub Khan made him deeply unpopular among students and the broader public. Instead of weakening the movement, his actions strengthened student unity and determination.

## Dhaka University Convocation Incident (21 December 1963)

The most dramatic moment of the movement occurred during the **Dhaka University Convocation on 21 December 1963**.

President Ayub Khan attended as the chief guest. Students boycotted the ceremony and staged protests outside the venue. Police attacked the demonstrators, injuring many and escalating nationwide outrage. This incident intensified the confrontation between the state and students and transformed the agitation into a broad political campaign.

## Expansion of the Movement (1964)

During **1964**, the agitation spread widely. Students demanded:

1. restoration of parliamentary democracy,
2. regional autonomy for East Pakistan,
3. an end to political repression, and
4. fair economic and administrative treatment.

Protests in Dhaka, Chittagong, Rajshahi, and Khulna became more coordinated and more challenging to the regime. By the end of **1964**, the movement had turned into one of the strongest organized forces opposing Ayub Khan's rule.

## Evaluation of the Movement

Evaluating the movement shows both its strengths and limitations.

### Strengths

1. **Organized leadership:** Student organizations acted with unity and discipline across institutions.
2. **Clear political direction:** The movement successfully linked campus demands with national democratic issues.
3. **Public support:** Repeated repression, especially under Monem Khan, increased public sympathy and involvement.
4. **Moral legitimacy:** Students became the moral voice against authoritarianism, especially after the 21 December 1963 incident.

### Limitations

1. **Lack of national coordination:** Although strong in East Pakistan, the movement did not find equal support in West Pakistan.
2. **Absence of a political settlement:** The demands were clear, but the government remained unwilling to compromise.

Even with these limitations, the movement left a lasting impact.

## **Importance of the Movement**

The 1962–1964 student movement is considered a milestone in the political history of East Pakistan for several reasons.

### **1. First major challenge to Ayub Khan**

It was the earliest large-scale movement that questioned the legitimacy of Ayub Khan's authoritarian system.

### **2. Strengthened democratic culture**

Students revived democratic debate, activism, and political consciousness at a time when political parties were weak.

### **3. Mobilized future political movements**

The strategies, networks, and leadership that emerged during 1962–64 later played crucial roles in the mass uprisings of **1966**, **1969**, and ultimately **1971**.

### **4. Exposed regional discrimination**

The protests highlighted how political, economic, and educational discrimination against East Pakistan was institutionalized under Ayub Khan.

### **5. Strengthened national identity**

The cultural and educational issues raised during the Sharif Commission agitation strengthened the Bengali sense of identity and autonomy.

### **6. Shifted public opinion against authoritarian rule**

The crackdown at the **21 December 1963 DU Convocation** became a turning point, showing the brutality of the regime and shifting public sentiment strongly toward democratic reform.

## **Conclusion**

The student movement of 1962–1964 was not just a campus protest; it was a national awakening. Its combination of political activism, educational demands, and moral courage laid the foundation for the later mass mobilizations that transformed East Pakistan's political landscape. It remains one of the most important democratic movements in the region's history.

# Indo-Pakistan War of 1965

## Introduction

The Indo-Pakistan War of 1965 was the second major military conflict between India and Pakistan after 1947. The core issue was the unresolved question of Kashmir. The war shaped political relations in South Asia for decades and revealed the deep tensions between the two states formed after partition.

## Causes of the War

### 1. Long-standing Kashmir Dispute

Since 1947 both countries claimed Kashmir. The ceasefire line from the first war never solved the political conflict. Frequent skirmishes kept the region tense.

### 2. Operation Gibraltar

Pakistan believed Kashmiris were ready to rise against Indian control. In August 1965 it sent infiltrators disguised as locals to trigger an insurgency. This miscalculation pushed the conflict into open war.

### 3. Border Clashes in Rann of Kutch

Earlier in April–May 1965 India and Pakistan fought a limited battle in the Rann of Kutch. Though a ceasefire was arranged, mistrust deepened on both sides and set the stage for a larger conflict.

### 4. Breakdown of Diplomacy

Repeated talks on Kashmir had failed. Both sides were convinced that negotiation would not produce any meaningful change.

## Major Events of the War

### 1. Infiltration in Kashmir (August 1965)

Pakistan attempted to create an internal uprising in Kashmir. India quickly detected the operation and responded with force.

### 2. India's Counter-attack (1–6 September 1965)

Indian troops crossed the ceasefire line and took control of several strategic points. On 6 September, India opened a major front across the international border near Lahore. This escalated the conflict into full-scale war.

### 3. Major Battles

*Battle of Asal Uttar:* One of the largest tank battles in the region's history, ending with heavy Pakistani losses.

*Fighting in Sialkot and Chawinda:* Intense tank engagements continued as both sides attempted to gain advantage.

*Air Warfare:* Both air forces carried out major bombing missions, hitting military bases, supply routes, and strategic locations.

#### **4. International Pressure and Ceasefire**

By mid-September the war reached a point where neither side could achieve a decisive victory. Global powers applied pressure. On 22 September 1965, both countries accepted a UN-sponsored ceasefire.

#### **5. Tashkent Agreement (January 1966)**

The Soviet Union mediated talks between President Ayub Khan and Indian Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri. Both sides agreed to withdraw to pre-war positions.

### **Consequences**

#### **1. Military Stalemate**

Neither country gained a clear victory. Both achieved some successes but failed to change the status of Kashmir.

#### **2. Political Impact on Pakistan**

Ayub Khan's image suffered. Many Pakistanis questioned his leadership and military strategy. This dissatisfaction weakened his regime and contributed to his eventual fall.

#### **3. Political Impact on India**

India viewed the war as a demonstration of its military capability. Prime Minister Shastri earned national respect, though he passed away shortly after the Tashkent Agreement.

#### **4. Strengthening of Nationalism**

The war intensified nationalism in both countries and hardened public attitudes on the Kashmir issue.

#### **5. Long-term Tension**

Instead of resolving disputes, the war deepened mistrust. It became one more step toward the much larger conflict of 1971.

### **Conclusion**

The Indo-Pakistan War of 1965 was a turning point that exposed the fragility of regional peace. Although it ended without territorial changes, it reshaped political thinking in both states. Above all, it reinforced the idea that the Kashmir dispute could not be ignored and would continue to define relations between India and Pakistan.

# Six-Point Programme

## Introduction

The Six-Point Programme is one of the most significant political documents in the history of East Pakistan. Formulated by Sheikh Mujibur

Rahman in 1966, it outlined the framework for East Pakistan's autonomy and highlighted the growing political and economic inequality between the eastern and western wings of Pakistan. The programme transformed vague public discontent into a clear constitutional demand and became the central rallying point for the Awami League and the people of East Pakistan. It was the first formal, detailed proposal that sought to address decades of neglect and exploitation, eventually laying the foundation for the creation of Bangladesh.

## 1. Background and Reasons Behind the Six-Point Programme

### a. Centralised military rule under Ayub Khan

Ayub Khan's regime (1958–1969) was highly centralised. Political power was concentrated in West Pakistan, and East Pakistan had minimal representation in the government. Provincial issues were ignored, and decision-making processes excluded East Pakistanis.

### b. Economic disparity and exploitation

East Pakistan contributed the majority of Pakistan's foreign exchange, mainly through jute exports, yet it received a tiny fraction of industrial and development investment. By the 1960s, economic neglect had caused widespread poverty, unemployment, and underdevelopment in East Pakistan compared to the relatively prosperous West Pakistan.

### c. Ineffective Constitution of 1962

The 1962 Constitution strengthened the presidential system, weakened parliamentary representation, and reduced provincial autonomy. This sidelined East Pakistan's voice and limited its participation in governance.

### d. Frustration after the 1965 Indo-Pakistan War

The war revealed the strategic vulnerability of East Pakistan. The central government's failure to adequately defend the eastern wing intensified fears that East Pakistan's interests would never be protected under a West Pakistan-dominated government.

### e. Failure of previous autonomy movements

Previous movements, including the United Front's 1954 provincial victory, had failed to achieve lasting autonomy due to central government resistance. East Pakistan needed a structured and decisive plan that could not be ignored.

## 2. Presentation of the Proposal by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman first presented the Six Points at the **opposition leaders' conference in Lahore on 5 February 1966**. His aim was to convince the opposition to adopt a federal system giving maximum autonomy to the provinces.

However, the West Pakistani opposition leaders immediately rejected the proposal. They argued that it would weaken the central government and could lead to the breakup of Pakistan. Because of their refusal, they **denied the inclusion of the Six Points in the joint opposition agenda**. Realising that no compromise could protect East Pakistan's rights, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman **left the conference**, determined to take the issue directly to the people of East Pakistan.

Later, the Awami League held a **special council session in Dhaka on 18 March 1966**, where the Six-Point Programme was **formally adopted as the party's official manifesto**. From this point, it became the blueprint of the autonomy movement, shaping every political decision of the Awami League until the Liberation War.

## 3. The Six Points

### Point 1: Federal system with parliamentary government

The central government would only oversee defense and foreign affairs, while all other powers would rest with the provinces. Representation would be based on population through universal adult franchise. *Significance:* East Pakistan, being the majority population, would gain proportional political power.

### Point 2: Limiting central government powers

Defense and foreign affairs would be the only responsibilities of the centre; everything else would be managed by provinces. *Significance:* Real autonomy over education, health, agriculture, industry, and commerce.

### Point 3: Control over currency and capital flow

Either two separate currencies for the two wings or strict controls on the flow of capital from East to West Pakistan.

Provinces would collect and spend their own taxes.

*Significance:* East Pakistan would retain its earnings for development instead of sending them to West Pakistan.

### Point 5: Separate foreign exchange accounts

Foreign exchange earnings, especially from jute exports, would be controlled by East Pakistan and kept in separate accounts. *Significance:* Ensured East Pakistan's economic resources were not exploited by the centre.

## **Point 6: Provincial control over militia or paramilitary forces**

Provinces would have authority over local armed forces for internal security.

*Significance:* East Pakistan could maintain its law and order independently and protect its population.

## **4. Importance of the Six-Point Programme**

### **a. Provided a clear and structured plan for autonomy**

For the first time, East Pakistan's demands were articulated

in a constitutional and systematic way.

### **b. United all sections of society**

Students, professionals, peasants, workers, and intellectuals found a common cause in the Six Points.

### **c. Strengthened Awami League leadership**

It made Sheikh Mujibur Rahman the undisputed leader of East Pakistan and the symbol of resistance against exploitation.

### **d. Forced West Pakistan to acknowledge the autonomy debate**

The central government and West Pakistani elites could no longer ignore East Pakistan's demands.

### **e. Foundation for future political struggle**

The Six Points became the manifesto for the 1970 general elections and formed the basis for all constitutional negotiations leading up to the Liberation War.

## **5. Consequences of the Six-Point Programme**

### **a. Repression by the central government**

The West Pakistani regime accused Mujibur Rahman of separatism and arrested him in

the **Agartala Conspiracy Case (1968)**. **b. Rise of the 1969 mass uprising**

Public outrage over Mujibur Rahman's arrest escalated into a massive movement, ultimately forcing Ayub Khan to resign.

### **c. Awami League's overwhelming victory in 1970 elections**

The Six Points were the manifesto for the elections, and the party won 167 out of 169 East Pakistan seats, giving it an absolute majority in Pakistan's National Assembly.



#### **d. Political deadlock and resistance from West Pakistan**

Despite the election results, West Pakistan refused to transfer power. This deepened the political crisis and heightened tensions.

#### **e. Path to independence**

Following the military crackdown on **25 March 1971**, the Six-Point Programme became the ideological foundation for the Liberation War and the eventual creation of Bangladesh.

**Conclusion:** The Six-Point Programme was more than a political proposal; it was the blueprint for East Pakistan's liberation. It highlighted decades of political neglect and economic exploitation, unified the people under a common cause, and transformed Sheikh Mujibur Rahman into a national leader. The programme not only shaped East Pakistan's political discourse but also directly led to the 1970 election victory, the constitutional crisis, and the Liberation War. Its importance in Bangladesh's history cannot be overstated—it laid the foundation for freedom, justice, and self-determination.